

Presence and Therapeutic Listening



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KEYWORDS

- Presence • Nursing presence • Therapeutic listening • Therapeutic relationship
- Nurse-patient relationship

KEY POINTS

- Presence and therapeutic listening are 2 critical elements in any complementary therapies used to develop a therapeutic nurse-patient relationship.
- Presence can affect patient outcomes by decreasing stress and anxiety, increasing safety and recovery, and producing an overall increase in patient satisfaction.
- Patient outcomes influenced by therapeutic listening include psychological benefits, promoting healing and recovery, and increasing quality of life and patient satisfaction.

INTRODUCTION

Complementary therapies have become widely known and used in Western health care because they play a key role in promoting healing, comfort, and care worldwide. Two therapies, presence and communication, are critical elements in the implementation of any of the complementary therapies.¹ Creating optimal health and/or healing environments with the implementation of complementary therapies, such as presence and therapeutic listening, is not limited by the environment or population.

The nurse-patient relationship, which is built on mutual trust and respect, is an important part of the nursing process. Trust is considered one of the most valuable concepts of communication and is directly related to effective communication, which is a major determinant of patient satisfaction.^{2,3} Communication breakdown continues to be a problem within health care.³ Building the nurse-patient relationship can be a difficult endeavor because of the numerous demands placed on nurses, and they must find a way to make patients feel valued and heard.

Healthy therapeutic nurse-patient relationships enhance wholeness and healing: they are key to effective health promotion.⁴ Nurses must be able to incorporate the skills, knowledge, and attitude that allows the nurse-patient relationships to meet the patient where they are and build to a therapeutic relationship to implement

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presence and therapeutic listening. This article discusses the nurse's role in facilitating complementary therapies of presence and therapeutic listening, barriers encountered, and the techniques to be used. It also discusses the impact that using presence and therapeutic listening has on patient outcomes.

PRESENCE

Nursing presence is a complex concept that has not been well delineated in the nursing literature; nevertheless, despite the lack of clarity, it is central to concepts of caring and to behaviors such as listening and touch.⁵ Nursing presence is both tangible and obscure at the same time. Therapeutic nursing presence shows caring, empathy, and connection, qualities required to build rapport and trust between nurse and patient.⁴ Nursing presence is considered to be an essential state of holistic nursing as well as a core competency in contemporary nursing.⁴ The concept of presence varies according to people's personal history of belief, sensory experience, and truths.^{4,6}

DEFINITION

Nursing presence has been described as the art of nursing and is characterized as the "intentional use of self by the nurse who enters a reciprocal relationship with the patient, from an existential view."⁷ Bright⁵ (2015) described nursing presence as a "humanitarian quality of relating to a patient that is known to have powerful and positive implications for both nurse and patient." Mohammadipour and colleagues⁸ (2017) provide an operational definition of nursing presence: "nursing presence is a concept that occurs via nurse-patient interactions within the health experience manifested through nurse's desire to begin interacting with patients, active listening, eye contact, calm speech, empathy, and subsequently accountable encounter."

NURSE'S ROLE

The concept of presence has long had roots in nursing, going back to Florence Nightingale, during the Crimean War, where she was known for establishing a nursing presence at the bedside of soldiers. Nightingale delivered compassion and care by dressing wounds, writing letters to soldiers' wives and mothers, and cared for the dying with a healing presence. This healing presence was attributed to her calm voice, warm smile, and gentle touch, which conveyed hope and trust. Nursing presence remains of interest to nursing scholars to this day. Patricia Benner⁹ was essential in developing the concept of presence in contemporary nursing. Benner,⁹ through her work:

1. Explained that nurses were trained to believe they were most effective by doing for the patient, not understanding that being with the patient could be as therapeutic
2. Designated the verb *presencing* as one of the 8 competencies of the helping role of the nurse
3. Explained that professional maturity, either innately or with experience, permits nurses to immerse themselves in a more meaningful exchange⁹

Benner⁹ (1984) describes the expert nurse as one that can show the quality of presence. This work all lays the foundation for professional nurses now to be trained and skilled to provide nursing presence in nurse-patient relationships and to identify the value they provide to patient outcomes.⁹

In the nurse's role, nurses must be able to provide the physical, psychological, and spiritual presence, meeting the patients where they are for positive patient outcomes. If nursing presence is implemented correctly, the shared moments between the patient and nurse via relational connection facilitate participation with the patients and therefore enhance the nurse's ability to provide patient-centered care.^{6,8}

NURSING BEHAVIORS

Nursing behaviors assisting in providing a positive nursing presence include:

- Using smiling
- Positive energy
- Holding silence with a patient
- Active listening
- Nurse's desire to begin interacting with patients
- Eye contact
- Calm speech
- Empathy^{6,8,10}

There are also techniques that can be used by nurses that patients could view as providing a presence, which include:

- Mindfulness meditation
- Breathing techniques
- Guided imagery^{6,8,10}

Although these subtle behaviors seem to be those that all nurses would use in any caring patient relationship, there is a more comprehensive nature of nursing presence that sets it apart from caring.⁶ Nursing presence is not to change or intervene but to bear witness to the patient experiences in a nonjudgmental manner.^{8,10}

BARRIERS

Many barriers prevent professional nurses from practicing with the intent of presence or using presence as an intervention with their patients. Modern nursing practice occurs in a system heavily influenced by protocols, standards of practice, staff shortages, equipment (technical, new, or shortage), lack of supportive environments, and endless lists of tasks to be accomplished.^{5,6} Additional barriers include:

- Time
- Acuity of patients
- Training of nurses
- Technology
- Landscape of health care
- Willingness of patients
- Telehealth advances in health care

As the landscape of health care changes from acute care settings to population health in the community, nursing roles and expectations change. There are fewer nurses and higher-acuity patients in the acute care settings, which prevents nurses from always facilitating meaningful connections with patients. Technological advances in health care and communication have dramatically altered the landscape of caring in contemporary nursing practice in both acute care and community settings.¹¹ As already discussed, novice nurse may not have the maturity or experience to implement nursing presence in their practices. Health care has moved to virtual/

distance environments, and telehealth assessments can prevent nurses from maintaining a physical nursing presence with their patients along with making a personal connection with them.

THERAPEUTIC LISTENING

Therapeutic listening is one of the many tools nurses can use to help build the trust and respect that are needed. Therapeutic listening can convey empathy and confirm personal experience.¹² It can also facilitate growth and help convey warmth, empathy, and genuineness, qualities that are needed for growth.^{12,13} Therapeutic listening can result in positive patient outcomes by reducing uncertainty, being perceived as trustworthy, friendly, and understanding.¹² Also, nurses who possess good listening skills can produce more satisfying interactions between patients and their physicians.¹² Therapeutic listening can also produce a sense of safety and understanding.¹⁴ When therapeutic listening is achieved and the therapeutic relationship forms, effective communication can take place, leading to improvements in patient satisfaction, treatment adherence, quality of life, and anxiety and depression.¹⁵

DEFINITION

Listening, simply defined, means hearing or giving attention with the ear, but therapeutic listening goes far beyond and encompasses the art of being present, being alert to verbal and nonverbal cues, conveying warmth, and conveying an interest in the patient's current state.¹⁶ Therapeutic listening can be defined as "an interpersonal, confirmation process involving all the senses in which the therapist attends with empathy to the client's verbal and nonverbal messages to facilitate the understanding, synthesis, and interpretation of the client's situation."¹³ It can also be defined as a "method of responding to others to encourage better communication and cleared understanding of personal concerns."¹⁷ For nursing, this is an important intervention that can be used to improve patient outcomes.

NURSE'S ROLE

The nurse's role in using therapeutic listening is to help facilitate and maintain the supportive, therapeutic relationship. It sounds simple but it takes work on the part of the nurse because therapeutic listening is a dynamic process that includes empathic responding with words and actions.¹⁸ Nurses must be present and attentive to both the verbal and nonverbal communication that occurs within the interaction. Certain cues, such as facial expressions or tone of voice, are equally important as what is said. Nonverbal cues are presented in [Table 1](#). Nurses must be alert for congruence between the verbal and nonverbal communication, because mixed messages may require reflection or validation to ensure that the message is clearly understood.¹⁹ Cultural norms are an essential component of communication that should always be considered when interacting. For example, tone and pitch, facial expressions, and closeness when communicating can depend on cultural norms.^{13,19}

There are other qualities that nurses can possess that lend themselves to therapeutic listening. These qualities help establish the trust and respect needed to ensure that the therapeutic relationship is established. Not every patient encounter requires therapeutic listening, but nurses must be prepared in any case. The following qualities are useful and [Table 2](#) discusses them in depth:

- Presence
- Self-awareness

Behavior	Possible Cues	Possible Meanings
Facial expressions	• Frowns • Smiles • Raised eyebrows • Grimacing	• Happiness • Sadness • Anger • Fear • Can be influenced by culture
Gaze and eye contact	• Intimidating gaze • Lowering brows • Avoidance of eye contact	• Respect • Lack of interest • Upsetting
Gesture and body movement	• Posture • Hand movements • Body movements • Gait/pacing • Head nodding • Touch	• Interest or lack thereof • Openness • Gestures can have different culture meanings
Spatial behavior	• Closeness of others	
Physical appearance	• Clothing • Grooming • Hygiene	• Lack of interest • Energy

Data from Watanuki S, Tracy MF, Lindquist R. Therapeutic listening. In: Watanuki S, Tracy MF, Lindquist R, ed. *Complementary & alternative therapies in nursing*. 7th ed. New York: Springer; 2014: 39-50 and Varcarolis EM. *Communication and the clinical interview*. In: Halter MJ, ed. *Foundations of psychiatric mental health nursing*. 7th ed. Missouri: Elsevier; 2014: 147-164.

- Compassion
- Empathy
- Respect and understanding

BARRIERS

Nurses realize the importance of therapeutic listening and effective communication but often are faced with increased patient loads and list of tasks that take away from important patient interactions. Barriers include:

- Time
- Tasks

Being present	• Sets the intent of being there to listen • Allows nurses to listen and detect verbal/nonverbal cues
Using self-awareness	• Understanding of nurse's own values and beliefs • Aware of limitations
Showing compassion	• Establishment of caring
Empathizing with experiences	• Establishment of a caring environment • Establishes nonjudgmental acceptance
Convey respect and understanding	• Establishes rapport

Data from Refs.^{2,5,6,10}

- Opportunities
- Charting/paperwork
- Administrative roles¹²

These barriers can directly affect the patients’ perceptions of care. Patients report wanting someone to sit down and talk, personal contact, and to feel like they are more than a task, and therapeutic listening is one way to achieve this.⁷ Patients with cancer have expressed feeling being undervalued, disrespected, and feeling ignored when they are not heard, which in turn leads to poor communication, and can affect the nurse-patient relationship.¹⁸

SKILLS AND TECHNIQUES

There are numerous skills and techniques used to facilitate therapeutic listening. It takes time to master this skill because it requires being fully present and truly listening, all while maintaining eye contact, maintaining attentive body language, and deciphering the verbal and nonverbal cues of the patient.^{1,6,11} Because of time constraints and other barriers mentioned earlier, nurses may become distracted and not adequately focus on what is being conveyed or may miss an incongruence between what is said and the accompanying nonverbal cues.⁵ In this instance, clarifying is a technique that can be used to assist in verifying the interpretation of the message or to create clarity.⁵ Being present or giving good attention can be achieved by making adequate eye contact, leaning slightly forward, and giving short responses such as “uh-huh,” and in turn can make patients comfortable and more willing to talk.^{5,6}

Other techniques are summarized in [Table 3](#).

OUTCOMES OF PRESENCE AND THERAPEUTIC LISTENING

Presence and therapeutic listening have been shown to positively affect several patient outcomes. Several themes were evident in the literature when researching patient

Table 3 Therapeutic listening techniques	
Silence	• Can be supportive • Allows time to think and formulate response • Reduces leading questions and lets nurse focus on message
Accepting attitude	• Nonjudgmental acknowledgment that patient has been heard • Creates a safe environment
Clarifying statements	• Verify the message • Avoid “why” questions
Restating	• Establishment of a caring environment • Establishes nonjudgmental acceptance
Reflecting	• Encourages self-understanding by directing feelings and ideas back to patient • Encourages patients to think for themselves • Paraphrasing to check understanding
Summarizing	• Brings everything together • Allows for clarification of any misinterpreted information
Making observations	• Uses nonverbal clues to verify message if incongruence between verbal and nonverbal message

Data from Refs. [3,13,14,19–21](#)

outcomes from using nursing presence and therapeutic listening. The main themes included decrease in stress and anxiety, increase in safety and recovery, and overall increase in patient satisfaction.^{22,23}

Psychological benefits were seen in women with postpartum depression, who reported a decreased rate of anxiety and depression after having someone listen to them.¹⁷ Others reported nursing presence and listening reducing the stress and anxiety brought on by illness.^{8,10,24} Some patients have noted the importance having nursing presence and listening has on gathering clinical data and the ability to choose appropriate interventions, because they think their input is often ignored.²⁴

As patient outcomes continue to be researched, there are several identified potential patient outcomes that are starting to appear in the literature. There is potential for increased treatment compliance when patients feel their input has been heard and that they are part of the team.²⁴ This outcome could be anything from a decrease in falls and pressure ulcers to changes in behavior modification with diet and exercise.²² For adults living in long-term care settings, nursing presence and therapeutic listening can potentially increase quality of life, feelings of satisfaction and being grateful, and feelings of being cared about.^{25,26} Presence and listening have the potential to create conditions that promote healing and recovery while also strengthening the therapeutic relationship. Patients reported valuing being treated as a unique individual, valuing being respectfully attended to, and an increase in nursing listening and nurse courtesy.^{7,27}

The following is an example of how, by implementing a few of the techniques and behaviors of presence and therapeutic listening, professional nurse can create an environment for a trusting nurse-patient relationship and improved patient outcomes.

Example of Nursing Presence and Therapeutic Listening

A 56-year-old woman with hypertension is in for a check-up after having her medications changed because of uncontrolled hypertension. On assessment, the client's blood pressure is 186/98 mm Hg.

The patient becomes upset and states, "I have too much going on right now. My husband has been laid off, and I am taking care of my elderly mother."

The nurse, putting everything down and turning and leaning toward the patient, calmly states: "Tell me more about what is going on."

Client: "I have so much going on. I am helping my husband look for a new job and I have to take my mother to all of her appointments. Money is tight. I keep forgetting to take my medication."

Nurse: "You are very busy and this is a stressful time."

Client: "Yes, and I want to get my blood pressure under control, but I can't seem to make it a priority. I am so overwhelmed."

The nurse nods and calmly states: "Can you take a couple of deep breaths for me and when you're ready [short pause] go on."

Client: "I don't know how to remember to take them! [Sigh] Do you think if I should set an alarm on my phone and see if that helps? Maybe that would be a good reminder to take my pills."

Nurse: "You said that you're stressed and very busy. It sounds like you are overwhelmed, but you seem to have found a solution you are willing to try that could help."

SUMMARY

Presence and therapeutic listening are 2 complementary therapies that are incorporated into daily nursing practice. This article presents the nurse's role in facilitating

complementary therapies of presence and therapeutic listening, barriers encountered, and the behaviors and techniques to be used. Also discussed was the impact that using presence and therapeutic listening has on patient outcomes. Nurses recognize the benefit and want time to be present and listen to what their patients have to say. These interventions have the potential to significantly alter patient' perceptions of care and improve patient outcomes. Presence and therapeutic listening are vital to developing a therapeutic nurse-patient relationship. This relationship is what drives positive patient outcomes and increases overall satisfaction and quality of care.

DISCLOSURE

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